

PlayStake Master Compliance Manual

Operator	[COMPANY NAME] (company no. [REG NO]), trading as PlayStake
Registered office	[REGISTERED ADDRESS]
Website	playstake.org
Licence applied for	Remote operating licence — betting intermediary (peer-to-peer wagering on skill-based games). <i>To be confirmed with legal advisers before submission.</i>
Document owner	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME], Head of Compliance and Money Laundering Reporting Officer (MLRO)
Approved by	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME], for and on behalf of the board
Version	0.1 — draft for licence application
Effective date	[DATE OF APPROVAL]
Next review	12 months from approval, or sooner on a material change (see section 7)

Draft status. This manual and the policies it indexes were prepared from the PlayStake platform as built on 30 September 2026. They describe controls that exist in the software today, and they flag clearly where something still depends on a contract, a person or a decision. Before submission, they must be reviewed by a qualified gambling-compliance adviser or solicitor. They must also be checked against the Gambling Commission's Licence Conditions and Codes of Practice (LCCP) and guidance current at that time, as requirements are updated frequently. Paragraph references to the LCCP are given for orientation and must be confirmed.

1. Purpose and scope

This manual is the top-level description of how PlayStake meets the licensing objectives in section 1 of the Gambling Act 2005:

1. preventing gambling from being a source of crime or disorder, being associated with crime or disorder, or being used to support crime;
2. ensuring gambling is conducted in a fair and open way;
3. protecting children and other vulnerable persons from being harmed or exploited by gambling.

It applies to every person who works for or on behalf of PlayStake, including directors, employees, contractors and outsourced providers. It also covers every part of the PlayStake service: the website at playstake.org, the lobby and challenge system, streamed matches refereed through Kick, the demo and skill games at /play, payments and withdrawals, and all back-office tooling.

2. The business in brief

PlayStake is a peer-to-peer platform where adult customers wager against each other on the outcome of skill-based games they play themselves:

- **Opponents are other customers.** PlayStake never takes the other side of a bet. It holds both stakes in escrow and pays the winner. It earns a platform fee (a percentage of the pot) on settled matches.
- **Match types.**
 - *Lobby matches* are played in PlayStake's own games (darts, cards, tic-tac-toe). The game reports the result.
 - *Streamed matches* are played in third-party games while both players broadcast on Kick. An independent, approved human referee watches both streams and records the result, and every referee action is written to a tamper-evident, hash-chained audit trail.
- **Money.** All money moves through a double-entry ledger with a per-match escrow account. The ledger is audited automatically every night.
- **Disputes.** Either player can dispute a result before it pays out. Payout pauses while the dispute is reviewed.

This business model shapes the risk profile, which is covered in detail in the AML Risk Assessment (Policy 07):

- **Main crime risk.** Two customers could pass money between themselves by one deliberately losing ("chip dumping").
- **Main integrity risk.** A result could be manipulated.
- **Main harm risks.** Loss-chasing and spending beyond one's means are amplified by play that is fast and competitive.

3. Governance and key people

PlayStake is a small operator at launch. One person currently holds all the key compliance roles:

Role	Holder	Responsibilities
Head of Compliance	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME]	Owns this manual and all policies. Monitors regulatory change. Reports to the board. Is the point of contact for the Gambling Commission.
Money Laundering Reporting Officer (MLRO)	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME]	Owns the AML risk assessment. Decides AML cases. Makes Suspicious Activity Reports (SARs) and Defence Against Money Laundering (DAML) requests to the NCA.
Customer Interaction / Safer Gambling Lead	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME]	Owns harm-signal review, customer interactions and the effectiveness evaluation.
Complaints Manager	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME]	Owns the complaints procedure. Issues final responses. Is the liaison with IBAS.
Personal Management Licence holders	[NAMES]	As required by the Commission for the specified management offices.

Segregation of duties. The Commission expects key functions, especially the MLRO, to be sufficiently senior, independent and resourced. While one person holds every role, PlayStake uses four compensating controls:

1. **Audit trail.** Every privileged action is written to an append-only admin audit log that the database itself protects from edits or deletion.
2. **Independent review.** An external compliance adviser, [ADVISER NAME / FIRM], reviews a sample of AML cases, harm-signal decisions and complaints every quarter.
3. **Built-in safeguards.** The software enforces the most important rules itself, so they don't depend on one person's judgement. For example:
 - age cannot be marked verified without an approved adult identity document
 - staff cannot change their own role
 - self-exclusion cannot be lifted early by anyone
 - staff can only ever lower a customer's deposit limit
4. **Separation as we grow.** Separate role holders will be appointed as the business grows, starting with the MLRO, and before monthly customer deposits exceed [THRESHOLD].

Board oversight. The board receives a compliance report every quarter covering:

- AML case volumes and outcomes, and any SARs made (numbers only)
- harm signals raised and the outcomes of interactions
- complaints: volumes, timeliness, outcomes and IBAS referrals
- ledger audit results
- any regulatory incidents or key-event notifications

4. The policies

No.	Policy	What it covers	Main controls in the platform
01	Crime Prevention and Fraud Controls	Account security, multi-accounting, collusion and match integrity, payment fraud, staff controls	2FA (required for staff), rate limits and lockouts, identity screening, head-to-head match cap, referee audit chain, double-entry ledger with nightly audit, chargeback suspension, append-only admin audit log
02	Complaints Procedure and ADR	How complaints are received, handled and escalated to IBAS	Reference numbers, immediate acknowledgement, 8-week deadline tracking with alerts, final-response letters naming IBAS
03	Self-Exclusion	Customer-requested self-exclusion and cool-off	6-month to 5-year exclusion, no early lifting, positive action plus 24-hour cooling-off to return, open activity withdrawn, marketing stopped, exclusion follows the person
04	Multi-Operator Self-Exclusion (GAMSTOP)	Participation in the national scheme	GAMSTOP checks at identity verification, login and before any deposit or stake; fails closed

No.	Policy	What it covers	Main controls in the platform
05	Customer Interaction and Harm Prevention	Identify, act and evaluate	Five automated harm markers, immediate in-app interaction, staff review queue, operator limits and cool-offs, 14-day outcome evaluation, deposit-limit prompt before first deposit, reality checks
06	Age Verification	Keeping under-18s out	Date of birth and 18+ confirmation at sign-up, document KYC before any deposit, free-to-play access or gambling, under-18 closure process
07	AML Risk Assessment and Controls	Money laundering and terrorist financing	Risk assessment, KYC, transaction monitoring (chip dumping, shared IPs, deposit-and-withdraw-without-play, EDD threshold), withdrawal holds, case management, SAR process

Each policy states its owner, its review date, the LCCP provisions it addresses, and exactly how the platform carries it out.

5. Cross-cutting controls

These controls support every policy.

5.1 One eligibility check in front of all gambling

Every deposit, every stake, and every entry to the games (including free-to-play) passes through a single check in the platform. It fails closed and checks, in order:

1. the account is **active**, not suspended or closed
2. the customer's **age and identity are verified**
3. they are **not registered with GAMSTOP**
4. they have **no cool-off or self-exclusion in force**

Withdrawals are deliberately outside this check. A self-excluded or GAMSTOP-registered customer can always take their money out.

5.2 Records and retention

- **Protected records.** Identity documents, self-exclusions and breaks, harm signals, customer interactions, complaints, AML cases and the admin audit log are all kept when a user record is deleted. The database refuses the deletion.
- **Identity documents.** These are encrypted at rest with AES-256-GCM and decrypted only when a reviewer deliberately opens one.
- **Retention periods.** The retention schedule is set out in the Privacy Policy. Financial, dispute, referee, AML and complaint records are kept for at least 5 years after the customer relationship ends, which meets the record-keeping expectation for AML purposes. **Outstanding:** an automated purge for records past their retention period is not yet built (see section 8).

5.3 Staff access

- **Role-based access.** Admin tools are restricted to the ADMIN role, checked on the server for every request.
- **Two-factor authentication.** Staff must use 2FA to reach admin tools in production.
- **Audit log.** Every privileged change is recorded in the append-only admin audit log: who, what, when, from which IP address, and why. This includes:
 - role and KYC changes
 - account suspensions and closures
 - KYC decisions
 - dispute resolutions
 - complaint handling
 - harm-signal actions
 - AML decisions
- **Viewing the log.** Staff can read the log at /admin/audit-log.

5.4 Training

All staff complete training before gaining access to customer data or admin tools, and refresh it every year. It covers:

- this manual
- AML and the tipping-off offence
- safer gambling and customer interaction
- complaints handling
- data protection

Completion is recorded in [TRAINING RECORD LOCATION].

5.5 Alerts

The platform emails the compliance inbox, [COMPLIANCE EMAIL] (configured as EMAIL_ADMIN), when:

- an AML case is opened
- a harm signal is raised
- an interaction has no effect
- a complaint is two weeks from, or past, its 8-week deadline
- the nightly ledger audit fails
- the anomaly scan detects unusual patterns on PlayStake's own games

Important: without EMAIL_ADMIN set these alerts are silently skipped. Setting it is a go-live requirement.

6. Regulatory reporting and notifications

The Head of Compliance keeps a calendar of regulatory returns and notifications, and is responsible for them:

- **Regulatory returns** to the Gambling Commission, submitted quarterly.
- **Key event notifications**, sent within the timescales in LCCP licence condition 15.2. These include:
 - a breach of the ledger's integrity
 - a significant security incident
 - a change of ADR provider
 - the appointment or departure of key people
- **Suspicious Activity Reports** to the NCA (see Policy 07). The Commission is told where the LCCP requires it.
- **Personal data breaches** reported to the ICO within 72 hours where required.

7. Review and change control

- **Scheduled review.** Every policy is reviewed at least once a year.
- **Earlier review.** A policy is also reviewed straight away after any of the following:
 - a new product, game type, payment method or technology
 - a material change in customer behaviour or risk indicators
 - a regulatory change
 - a significant incident or complaint trend
 - a finding from the quarterly independent review
- **Version control.** Changes are recorded in each document's version history and approved by the Head of Compliance and the board.
- **Code as documentation.** The platform's code is the operative description of each control. Any change to a compliance control in the code must reference the policy it implements and be reviewed by the Head of Compliance before release.

8. Outstanding items before submission

These must be done before the application is submitted, or before real-money launch as marked. Each is also noted in the relevant policy.

#	Item	Needed for	Owner
1	Complete company details, key people and PML holders throughout these documents	Application	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME]
2	Sign the ADR agreement with IBAS and confirm the referral terms. The site and emails state 6 months from the final response, which must be confirmed.	Application	Complaints Manager
3	Join GAMSTOP, then set <code>GAMSTOP_API_KEY</code> and <code>GAMSTOP_REQUIRED=true</code> in production. Also confirm field requirements: collecting a mobile number may improve match rates.	Launch	Head of Compliance

#	Item	Needed for	Owner
4	Appoint an electronic identity and age verification provider to supplement manual document review, including liveness and document-authenticity checks	Recommended before launch	Head of Compliance
5	Appoint a sanctions and PEP screening provider. Until then, check manually against the OFSI consolidated list at KYC approval and record the check in the review notes.	Launch	MLRO
6	Payments: move Stripe from test to live mode, switch to GBP, configure Stripe Radar rules and 3-D Secure, and match the payout account holder's name to the KYC legal name	Launch	Head of Compliance / engineering
7	Set <code>EMAIL_ADMIN</code> and <code>SENTRY_DSN</code> in production, and confirm alerts arrive	Launch	Engineering
8	Confirm every staff account has 2FA enabled (enforced in production)	Launch	Head of Compliance
9	Set the AML and affordability thresholds (<code>AML_*</code> , <code>AFFORDABILITY_REVIEW_THRESHOLD_CENTS</code>) to the values in the approved risk assessment, in GBP pence once currency changes	Launch	MLRO
10	Build automated data-retention purges matching the Privacy Policy	Within 3 months of launch	Engineering
11	Move rate limiting from per-process memory to Redis before running more than one web instance	Before scaling	Engineering
12	Add a Content-Security-Policy and frame-ancestors headers	Launch	Engineering
13	Update the website's licensing statement ("does not currently hold a gambling licence") to show the licence number once granted	On grant	Head of Compliance
14	Staff training programme and records	Launch	Head of Compliance
15	Engage the external compliance adviser for quarterly independent review	Launch	Board
16	Confirm the current Commission thresholds and rules on: financial vulnerability and affordability checks, consumer-set financial limit prompts, and marketing consent. Adjust the platform settings to match.	Application	Head of Compliance

9. Version history

Version	Date	Author	Change
0.1	30 September 2026	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME]	First draft for licence application

Policy 01 — Crime Prevention and Fraud Controls

Operator	[COMPANY NAME], trading as PlayStake
Owner	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME], Head of Compliance
Version	0.1 — draft for licence application
Review	Annually, and on any new product, payment method or significant incident
Relates to	Licensing objective 1 (keeping crime out of gambling) and objective 2 (fair and open gambling); LCCP licence condition 12 (anti-money laundering, see Policy 07) and conditions on cheating and security; Gambling Act 2005 s.42 (cheating)

Draft for review by a compliance adviser. LCCP references to be confirmed against the current version.

1. Purpose

This policy sets out how PlayStake stops its service being used to commit crime. It covers fraud against customers or against PlayStake, cheating and match-fixing, and misuse of accounts and payments. It also sets out what we do when crime is suspected. Money laundering and terrorist financing are covered in more depth in Policy 07.

2. Our main crime and fraud risks

Risk	Why it matters for PlayStake
Collusion and match-fixing	Customers play each other. Two accounts controlled by the same person or group can fix results, either to launder money (see Policy 07) or to defraud a third party.
Result manipulation	Results decide who gets paid. A forged or tampered result would move money unfairly.
Account takeover	A stolen account could be used to stake or withdraw another person's money.
Multi-accounting	One person running several accounts to collude, evade a self-exclusion or ban, or get round limits.
Payment fraud	Stolen cards used to deposit; chargebacks after playing or withdrawing ("friendly fraud").
Insider misuse	Staff with admin access changing records, approving identities improperly, or moving money.
Ledger error or tampering	Money created or destroyed through a software fault or deliberate change.

3. Controls

3.1 Account security

- **Passwords:**
 - at least 8 characters, with an uppercase letter, a number and a special character
 - hashed with bcrypt (cost 12); never stored or logged in plain text
- **Sign-in protection:**
 - 10 failed attempts in 15 minutes from one address triggers a 30-minute logout
 - sign-in requests are rate-limited
 - password resets are rate-limited
- **Sessions:**
 - random 256-bit tokens, stored only as hashes
 - cookies are HttpOnly, Secure and SameSite=Lax
 - sessions expire after 7 days
 - every session is revoked on a password change or reset
 - closed accounts are signed out everywhere and cannot sign in again
- **Two-factor authentication (TOTP):**
 - available to every customer
 - backup codes are stored hashed
 - codes cannot be replayed
 - setting up 2FA is rate-limited
- **Email verification** is required before identity verification or any withdrawal.
- **Cross-site request forgery:** browser requests that change data are refused if they come from another site.
- **Security headers:** HSTS, X-Content-Type-Options, Referrer-Policy and Permissions-Policy.
Outstanding: Content-Security-Policy and frame-ancestors (Master Manual §8).

3.2 One person, one account

Customers may hold only one account (Terms of Service). This is enforced as follows:

- **At identity verification:**
 - the platform compares each new submission with every other account
 - a match on the same legal name and date of birth, or an identical identity document image, opens a `SHARED_IDENTITY` case
 - approval of the new account is blocked until the case is resolved
- **Excluded or closed customers:**
 - if the matching account is self-excluded, the exclusion is applied to the new account immediately
 - staff reviewing the case will see if the other account was closed (for example, as under-18 or for fraud)
- **Shared IP addresses:** the AML scan reviews IP addresses used in the last 30 days:
 - accounts that have played each other from the same IP address open a high-severity `SHARED_IP` case

- four or more accounts on one address open a low-severity case for review
- **Date of birth check:** the date of birth declared at sign-up is checked against the identity document. A mismatch opens a `DOB_MISMATCH` case and blocks approval.

3.3 Match integrity and cheating

Cheating is an offence under s.42 of the Gambling Act 2005. PlayStake prevents and detects it as follows:

- **No self-play.**
 - the database refuses any bet where both players are the same account
 - the lobby and challenge flows refuse it before that point
- **Head-to-head cap.** The same two customers can play each other at most **5 times in any hour**. Repeated head-to-heads are how value is passed between colluding accounts.
- **Results for PlayStake's own games:**
 - the game itself reports the result
 - the reporting routes check that the caller is a player in that match and that the game session belongs to that bet (hardened against a previously identified exploit chain)
 - a player cannot move for, or report for, their opponent
- **Results for streamed matches** are decided by an independent human referee:
 - referees apply, are verified (identity and age), and are approved by staff for specific games
 - a referee cannot officiate a match they are playing in, and can hold only one match at a time
 - the match can only start while both players are live on Kick with the same game declared, so the referee can watch both feeds
 - every referee action is written to an append-only, hash-chained audit trail that the database protects from edits or deletion; anyone can verify the chain for a match
 - after a decision, either player has 15 minutes to dispute it before payout
- **Disputes.** Any result can be disputed before it pays out (see Policy 02). Staff decisions on disputes are recorded in the audit log.
- **Referee quality.** Overturned referee decisions are tracked per referee. Referees with a high overturn rate are reviewed and can be suspended.
- **Anomaly detection.** A scan every 15 minutes looks for:
 - win rates above 80%
 - winning streaks of more than 10
 - average settlement under 30 seconds
 - hourly volume spikes above 3 times normal

For third-party games it can automatically reduce the game's escrow cap or freeze the developer. For PlayStake's own games it alerts staff instead, so that two colluding players cannot take the whole site offline.

- **Chip-dumping detection** (Policy 07). The same pair playing 5 or more times in 7 days, with one side winning at least 80% and receiving at least a set amount, opens a `CHIP_DUMPING` case.

3.4 Payments

- Identity and age must be verified before any deposit or withdrawal.
- **Deposits:**
 - between \$5 and \$1,000 per transaction
 - at most 5 deposit attempts an hour from one address
 - also limited by the customer's own deposit limits
- **Withdrawals:**
 - rate-limited
 - blocked while the account is suspended
 - held for review when an AML case is open, when the amount is large, or when money is going straight back out with little play (Policy 07)
- **Idempotency.** Every money movement uses an idempotency key, so a retried request can never pay twice.
- **Stripe webhooks** are verified by signature and de-duplicated.
- **Chargebacks.** A card dispute on a deposit immediately suspends the account and opens a high-severity `CHARGEBACK` case.
- **Outstanding (Master Manual §8):**
 - Stripe live mode with Radar fraud rules and 3-D Secure
 - GBP currency
 - matching the payout account holder's name to the verified legal name

3.5 The ledger

- **Double-entry.** All money moves through a double-entry ledger. Exactly one function is allowed to change balances. It always writes a debit and a matching credit that sum to zero, and it refuses to take any player or escrow account below zero.
- **Escrow per match.** Each match has its own escrow account, which must net to zero when the match is settled or cancelled.
- **Nightly audit.** Every night at 03:00 UTC, an automatic audit checks:
 - every account balance against its entries
 - every transaction for balance
 - that the system as a whole conserves money

A failure alerts the compliance inbox and the error-monitoring service at the highest severity, for same-day investigation.

3.6 Staff and insider risk

Admin access is restricted as follows:

- **Access.** Admin tools are limited to the ADMIN role, checked on every request, and require two-factor authentication in production.
- **Audit trail.** Every privileged action is recorded in the append-only admin audit log, with the member of staff, time, IP address, what changed and the reason given.
- **Reasons required.** Staff must give a reason for every account-status, role and KYC change.
- **Rules staff cannot override.** The platform enforces these regardless of role:
 - staff cannot change their own role
 - staff cannot mark an identity as verified unless an approved identity document shows the customer is 18 or over
 - staff cannot lift or shorten a self-exclusion
 - staff can only lower a customer's deposit limit, never raise it
 - staff cannot reopen an account closed as under-18
- **Pre-employment checks.** Before being given admin access, staff complete [DBS / criminal record check and reference checks — to be confirmed].
- **Leavers.** Admin access is removed on the day a person leaves.

3.7 Software supply chain

- Every change is linted, type-checked and tested in CI before release.
- A malware scan runs on every push and weekly, following a 2026 supply-chain incident.
- Errors in production are reported to an error-monitoring service (Sentry).

4. When crime is suspected

1. **Contain.**
 - Suspend the account (`/admin/users` , with a reason). This stops deposits, stakes and withdrawals while still letting the customer sign in.
 - Unsettled matches can be voided with both stakes refunded where needed.
2. **Record.** Open or use an AML case (`/admin/aml`), and record the evidence and every decision on it.
3. **Decide.** The MLRO decides whether to:
 - make a Suspicious Activity Report (Policy 07)
 - report to the police or Action Fraud
 - notify the Gambling Commission as a key event
4. **Don't tip off.** Customers are not told that a report has been considered or made.
5. **Put it right.** Refund innocent third parties. Close accounts involved in fraud or cheating, and forfeit winnings obtained by cheating where the Terms allow.
6. **Learn.** Review the controls and update this policy.

5. Review

The Head of Compliance reviews this policy every year and after any significant incident. Any change to the controls described here requires an update to this document.

Version	Date	Change
0.1	30 September 2026	First draft

Policy 02 — Complaints Procedure and Alternative Dispute Resolution

Operator	[COMPANY NAME], trading as PlayStake
Owner	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME], Complaints Manager
ADR provider	IBAS — Independent Betting Adjudication Service (www.ibas-uk.com). <i>Agreement to be signed before submission.</i>
Version	0.1 — draft for licence application
Review	Annually, and on any change of ADR provider (a key event to notify to the Commission)
Relates to	LCCP social responsibility code 6.1.1 (complaints and disputes) and the ADR requirements; the Alternative Dispute Resolution for Consumer Disputes Regulations 2015

Draft for review by a compliance adviser. IBAS referral terms (including the time limit for referral) must be confirmed with IBAS when the agreement is signed.

1. Purpose

Customers must be able to complain easily, get a fair and timely answer, and take the complaint to an independent body if they are not satisfied. This policy explains how PlayStake makes that happen, and how the platform supports it.

2. What counts as a complaint

A **complaint** is any expression of dissatisfaction with PlayStake, whether spoken or written. That includes complaints about:

- the account, deposits or withdrawals
- a bet or its result
- a referee
- responsible-play tools
- how we have treated the customer
- how we handled an earlier dispute

A **result dispute** is a narrower, faster process. A player uses the dispute button on a bet to challenge a result before it pays out:

- **Timing:** within 24 hours of the result, or within 15 minutes of a referee's decision.
- **Effect:** payout pauses while staff review the game data, stream footage and referee evidence.

A customer unhappy with a dispute outcome can then make a complaint. Anything that is not a simple result challenge is handled as a complaint from the start. If in doubt, staff treat it as a complaint.

3. How customers complain

Customers can complain in two ways:

- **Online:** through the complaint form at playstake.org/complaints. It works whether or not the customer is signed in, so someone locked out of their account can still use it.
- **By email:** to support@playstake.org (the address is shown on the complaints page, in the footer, in the Terms of Service and on every email). Staff log each email complaint into the complaints system on the day it arrives.

The /complaints page explains, in plain English:

- how to complain
- what happens next and when
- the 8-week deadline
- how to take the complaint to IBAS, and that IBAS is free and independent
- how complaints relate to result disputes
- other organisations: the Gambling Commission (which cannot resolve individual complaints), the ICO for data protection, and GamCare for support

It is linked from the site footer, from the Terms of Service (sections 09 and 17) and from every complaint email.

4. How complaints are handled

Stage	What happens	Timescale	How the platform supports it
1. Received	Complaint recorded with a unique reference (PS-C-YYYY-NNNNNN), a category, and any linked bet (only a bet the customer was in can be linked).	Immediately	A database sequence issues references, so two complaints can never share one.
2. Acknowledged	The customer is emailed their reference, the date by which they will get a final response, and how to reach IBAS.	Immediately	Automatic acknowledgement email.
3. Investigated	A handler reviews the complaint and relevant records, and asks the customer for more information if needed. Internal notes and messages to the customer are recorded against the complaint.	As soon as possible	Staff queue at /admin/complaints, sorted by deadline. Overdue complaints are flagged in red, and those due within 14 days in amber.
4. Final response	A written decision (upheld, partially upheld, or not upheld) with the reasons, and what will be done to put things right. The letter explains how to refer the complaint to IBAS if the customer is not satisfied.	Within 8 weeks of receipt	The final-response email always includes the IBAS referral wording and link. Once it is issued, the complaint is locked.

Deadline alerts. The compliance inbox receives an alert when a complaint is 2 weeks from its 8-week deadline, and again if the deadline passes without a final response.

Accountability. Every staff action on a complaint is recorded in the append-only admin audit log: the note, message, status change or final response, and who made it.

5. Handling standards

- **Be fair.** Decide on the evidence, not on who the customer is or how they complained.
- **Keep money safe.** Where a bet or balance is involved, the funds stay protected while the complaint is investigated.
- **Be plain.** Write in clear English. Explain the reasons, not just the outcome.
- **Put it right.** If we got something wrong, correct it (including any money owed) and say what we will change.
- **Watch for harm.** If a complaint suggests the customer may be experiencing gambling harm, refer it to the Safer Gambling Lead and record a customer interaction (Policy 05).
- **Watch for crime.** If a complaint reveals suspected fraud or money laundering, refer it to the MLRO. Do not tip off the customer (Policy 07).

6. Alternative Dispute Resolution – IBAS

PlayStake's ADR provider is **IBAS**, the Independent Betting Adjudication Service. It is approved by the Gambling Commission as an ADR entity for gambling disputes.

- **When customers can refer:** once they have our final response and are not satisfied, or if we have not given a final response within 8 weeks.
- **Cost:** IBAS is free for customers.
- **Time limit:** customers should refer within six months of our final response. *This is the period stated on the site and in our emails; it must be confirmed against IBAS's terms when the agreement is signed.*
- **Where we tell customers about IBAS:** on the /complaints page, in the Terms of Service, in the acknowledgement email, and in every final-response email.
- **Our commitment:** PlayStake cooperates fully with IBAS, provides the records it asks for promptly, and complies with its decisions. *Confirm the binding nature of decisions against the IBAS agreement.*
- **Changing provider:** any change of ADR provider will be notified to the Commission as a key event, and the site and emails updated first.

7. Records and reporting

- **What is kept:** each complaint, its full history, the final response and the outcome. These are kept for at least 5 years and are not deleted with the customer's account.
- **Regulatory returns:** complaint volumes, categories, outcomes, timeliness and IBAS referrals are included in the Commission's regulatory returns.
- **Board reporting:** the same figures go into the quarterly board compliance report.

- **Trend review:** the Complaints Manager reviews complaint trends each quarter and feeds lessons into product and policy changes.

8. Review

Version	Date	Change
0.1	30 September 2026	First draft

Policy 03 — Self-Exclusion

Operator	[COMPANY NAME], trading as PlayStake
Owner	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME], Safer Gambling Lead
Version	0.1 — draft for licence application
Review	Annually
Relates to	LCCP social responsibility code 3.5.3 (self-exclusion, remote), and 3.5.6 (multi-operator self-exclusion — see Policy 04); marketing restrictions for self-excluded customers

Draft for review by a compliance adviser. LCCP references to be confirmed against the current version.

1. Purpose

Self-exclusion lets a customer stop themselves gambling with PlayStake for a period they choose. The period can't be undone while it runs. This policy explains:

- how customers self-exclude
- what happens while they are excluded
- how exclusion ends
- how the platform makes sure an excluded customer cannot gamble with us or be marketed to

It also covers the shorter **cool-off** break, which works in the same way for a shorter time. Participation in the national scheme, GAMSTOP, is covered in Policy 04.

2. Periods offered

Option	Periods
Self-exclusion	6 months, 1 year, 2 years, 5 years
Cool-off (take a break)	24 hours, 72 hours, 1 week, 1 month, 6 weeks

The minimum self-exclusion is six months.

3. How customers self-exclude

- **Self-service:** from **Responsible Play** in their account, available from every page in the account area.
 - The customer picks a period.
 - A confirmation screen explains in plain English:
 - what happens

- that the exclusion cannot be shortened or lifted early by the customer or by our staff
- that they can still sign in and withdraw their balance
- that anything waiting in a lobby, and any challenges, will be withdrawn
- that when the period ends the account stays closed to gambling until they ask to return
- The customer must confirm before the exclusion starts.
- **By contacting us:**
 - A customer can ask by email (support@playstake.org) or any other contact.
 - Staff apply it straight away from the customer's admin page, recording how the customer asked.
 - This is audited, and the same rules apply as for self-service.
 - Staff must never try to talk a customer out of self-excluding.
- **Confirmation:** the customer gets an email confirming the exclusion and its end date, with GamCare's details.
- **Signposting:** the Responsible Play page tells customers about GAMSTOP, so they can exclude from every UK-licensed online operator at once, and gives the contact details for GamCare (0808 8020 133) and BeGambleAware.

4. What happens during self-exclusion

From the moment a self-exclusion starts:

1. **No gambling.** Every deposit, stake and game entry passes the eligibility check (Master Manual §5.1). A self-excluded customer is refused at each of:
 - depositing
 - joining a lobby
 - sending an invite
 - accepting an invite or challenge
 - issuing a challenge
 - starting a free-to-play game
2. **Open activity is withdrawn.** The following are cancelled at once, so they cannot be drawn into a match:
 - the customer's waiting lobby entries
 - invites they have received
 - challenges they have sent or received

Nothing needs refunding at this point, because stakes are only taken once a match is agreed.
3. **They can't be pulled into a match by someone else.** If another player tries to accept a challenge from a customer who has since self-excluded, the platform re-checks the customer before taking their stake, and refuses. The other player is told only that the player "isn't available". The reason is never disclosed.
4. **Matches already agreed** before the exclusion run to their normal end and settle as usual. Voiding them would unfairly affect the opponent.

5. **Withdrawals stay open.** The customer can still sign in and withdraw their whole balance at any time. On request, staff close the account and return the balance.
6. **No marketing or optional emails.** While any break is in force, the customer receives only essential emails (security, payments, responsible play). They get no promotional email even if they previously consented to it, and no optional notifications. The same applies to customers registered with GAMSTOP and to restricted accounts.
7. **No early end.** The exclusion cannot be shortened or lifted by the customer or by staff. The platform only allows it to be replaced by a longer one.
8. **It follows the person.** If the excluded customer opens another account, the new account's identity documents are matched to them at verification. The same exclusion is applied to the new account automatically, and a case is opened for staff to review (Policy 01 §3.2).

5. How self-exclusion ends

A self-exclusion does **not** lapse on its own:

1. When the period ends, the customer is emailed. The email explains that their account **stays closed to gambling**, that nothing changes unless they choose to come back, how to return if they want to, and where to get support.
2. To return, the customer must take a **positive action**: asking to return from Responsible Play and confirming it.
3. Access then resumes after a **24-hour cooling-off period**. During that time the account stays closed, and the page shows when it reopens. The customer is encouraged to set deposit limits first.

A cool-off ends automatically at the end of its period, and the customer is emailed when it does.

6. Staff responsibilities

The Safer Gambling Lead is responsible for:

- applying self-exclusions requested by email or phone the same day, and recording how the request arrived
- never shortening, lifting or trying to talk a customer out of a self-exclusion (the platform prevents this anyway)
- when a shared-identity case shows a new account linked to a self-excluded person, confirming the exclusion was applied, and considering whether the customer should be contacted with support information
- making sure no marketing list or promotion ever includes excluded customers (the platform enforces this for its own emails; any external or manual marketing must be filtered against the platform's exclusion data first)
- checking a sample of self-exclusions every month, to confirm they were applied correctly and no gambling or marketing followed

7. Records

- **What is kept:** self-exclusions and breaks (start, end, return request, return effective date).
- **How long:** kept even if the customer's account is later deleted, for at least 5 years after the exclusion ends.
- **Audit trail:** staff-applied exclusions appear in the admin audit log.

8. Review

Version	Date	Change
0.1	30 September 2026	First draft

Policy 04 — Multi-Operator Self-Exclusion (GAMSTOP)

Operator	[COMPANY NAME], trading as PlayStake
Owner	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME], Head of Compliance
Version	0.1 — draft for licence application
Review	Annually, and on any change to GAMSTOP's integration requirements
Relates to	LCCP social responsibility code 3.5.6 — participation in the national online multi-operator self-exclusion scheme (GAMSTOP)

Draft for review by a compliance adviser. **Status: PlayStake has not yet joined GAMSTOP.** The integration is built and tested, and switches on with configuration once membership and API credentials are in place (section 6).

1. Purpose

GAMSTOP lets a person exclude themselves from every online gambling business licensed in Great Britain in one step. Remote operators must take part in the scheme and must not let a GAMSTOP-registered person gamble. This policy describes how PlayStake checks GAMSTOP and acts on the result.

2. When PlayStake checks GAMSTOP

The check needs the customer's identity. PlayStake uses the details from their identity-verification submission: legal first and last name, date of birth, postcode and email address.

When	What happens
Identity verification submitted	Checked as soon as identity is known, before the account is approved.
Every sign-in	Checked again on each sign-in. A GAMSTOP outage here never blocks sign-in, because the customer may need to withdraw.
Before any deposit, stake or game entry	The eligibility check (Master Manual §5.1) uses the stored result if it is under 24 hours old. Otherwise it checks GAMSTOP again first.

3. How the result is used

GAMSTOP result	What PlayStake does
Registered (excluded)	The customer cannot deposit, stake or play, and is told why in plain terms. They can still sign in and withdraw their balance . They receive no marketing or optional emails.

GAMSTOP result	What PlayStake does
Previously registered (exclusion lapsed)	Treated as not excluded for access. The fact is visible to staff on the customer's admin page, and staff may consider it in customer-interaction decisions.
Not registered	No restriction.
Check could not be completed (timeout or error)	Fails closed. The deposit or stake is refused with a "try again shortly" message, and the failure is logged. If a customer has never been checked, they cannot gamble until a check succeeds.

Staff view. The latest result and the time it was checked are shown on the customer's admin page.

Launch safeguard. A production setting (`GAMSTOP_REQUIRED=true`) makes the platform refuse all gambling if the GAMSTOP integration is ever switched off or misconfigured. Gambling can never quietly continue without the check.

4. Other controls that work alongside GAMSTOP

- **Signposting.** The Responsible Play page, and the site footer on every public page, tell customers about GAMSTOP and link to it.
- **Our own exclusion.** PlayStake's own self-exclusion (Policy 03) works independently of GAMSTOP, and applies to a person across all of their accounts.

5. Records

- **Stored on the account:** the latest GAMSTOP result and the time it was checked.
- **Logged:** failed checks.
- **Not stored:** the details sent to GAMSTOP are not kept in addition to the identity-verification record.

6. Go-live steps (outstanding)

1. Apply to join GAMSTOP and sign the operator agreement.
2. Obtain API credentials. Confirm the current API endpoint, the required fields, and how the response is returned. The integration expects GAMSTOP's operator API (form fields: first name, last name, date of birth, email, postcode, mobile; an `X-Exclusion` response header of Y, N or P). *Confirm against GAMSTOP's current specification.*
3. Decide whether to collect a **mobile number** at identity verification, since GAMSTOP accepts it and it may improve matching.
4. Set `GAMSTOP_API_KEY` and `GAMSTOP_REQUIRED=true` in production (and `GAMSTOP_API_URL` if GAMSTOP specifies a different endpoint).
5. Run GAMSTOP's test cases against the staging environment and keep the evidence.
6. Record the go-live date in this policy's version history.

7. Review

Version	Date	Change
0.1	30 September 2026	First draft; integration built, awaiting membership

Policy 05 — Customer Interaction and Harm Prevention

Operator	[COMPANY NAME], trading as PlayStake
Owner	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME], Safer Gambling Lead
Version	0.1 — draft for licence application
Review	Annually; the effectiveness data (section 6) is reviewed every quarter
Relates to	LCCP social responsibility code 3.4.3 (customer interaction, remote) and the Commission's customer interaction guidance ("identify, act, evaluate"); financial vulnerability / affordability requirements; restrictions on marketing to customers at risk; the requirement to offer financial limits

Draft for review by a compliance adviser. **The Commission's current thresholds for financial vulnerability checks and its rules on prompting customers to set limits must be confirmed, and PlayStake's thresholds set to match** (see section 3.2 and Master Manual §8 item 16).

1. Purpose

PlayStake must spot customers who may be experiencing, or be at risk of, gambling harm, act quickly and appropriately, and check whether what it did worked. This policy describes the system that does that.

Scale does not excuse us. Player-versus-player wagering on competitive games can be fast, emotional and repeated: a loss invites a rematch. PlayStake treats harm prevention as a core function, not an add-on.

2. Tools every customer has

These tools are available to every customer, from **Responsible Play** in their account:

- **Deposit limits:**
 - daily, weekly and monthly, over rolling periods
 - lowering a limit takes effect immediately
 - raising or removing a limit only takes effect after 24 hours, so it can't be done in the heat of a session
- **A limit prompt before the first deposit.** Before their first deposit, every customer must either set a deposit limit or actively decline to. The platform enforces this, not just the page, and records the answer.
- **Cool-off breaks and self-exclusion.** See Policy 03.
- **Reality checks:**
 - optional reminders every 15, 30, 60 or 120 minutes

- each one shows how long the customer has been playing, how many bets they have placed, how much they have staked, and their net result
- each one offers to take them to Responsible Play
- they run on the dashboard and on the game pages
- **Support information** from GamCare and BeGambleAware, and GAMSTOP signposting.

3. Identify: markers of harm

A scan runs **every 15 minutes**. It covers every customer who has played or deposited in the last 24 hours and looks for these markers:

Marker	Triggered when	Severity
Loss chasing — stakes	Three or more consecutive losses in 24 hours, with the last stake at least double the first	Low at 2×, medium at 3×, high at 4×
Loss chasing — deposits	Three or more deposits in 24 hours, each within 30 minutes of a losing result	Medium; high at six or more
Rapid deposits	Five deposits in an hour, or ten in 24 hours	Medium; high at double those numbers
High deposit volume (affordability)	Completed deposits over 30 days at or above the affordability threshold (setting <code>AFFORDABILITY_REVIEW_THRESHOLD_CENTS</code> ; currently 2,000.00)	Medium; high at double
Late-night play	Five or more bets settled between midnight and 6am UK time in 24 hours	Low; medium at ten or more

Signal frequency. Each marker raises a signal at most once in 24 hours per customer, or once in 30 days for high deposit volume, so a single episode doesn't flood the queue.

Other indicators staff consider during review. Some indicators are not yet automated. Staff consider them whenever they review a customer. They are:

- how the customer uses the gambling management tools, such as raising or removing limits or ending breaks
- repeated declined deposits or cancelled withdrawals
- time spent on the site
- a complaint or other contact that suggests distress
- anything else the customer tells us

Customer-led contact. Any contact from a customer that suggests harm, whether a complaint, an email or something else, must be recorded by staff as an interaction on that customer (see section 4.2).

3.1 Customers we already know about

Some customers are already handled before any scan runs. If a customer has self-excluded, is on a break, is registered with GAMSTOP, or has a restricted account, they cannot gamble at all.

3.2 Affordability and financial vulnerability

Current threshold. The high-deposit-volume marker is PlayStake's affordability trigger. It is set at 2,000.00 of deposits over 30 days.

Aligning with the Commission. Before launch, this threshold must be set at or below the level at which the Commission requires financial vulnerability checks. Our AML enhanced due diligence threshold (Policy 07, 5,000.00 over 30 days) requires source-of-funds evidence. Customers who cannot show that their spending is affordable are restricted.

Planned improvement. Adding a credit-reference-based financial vulnerability check is a planned improvement once a provider is appointed.

4. Act

4.1 Immediately, and automatically

When a marker is raised, three things happen straight away:

1. **The customer is contacted.** The next time they are on the site (dashboard or games), they see a supportive message suited to the marker. For example, for loss chasing: *"We noticed your stakes have been going up after a run of losses. Chasing losses is one of the most common ways gambling stops being fun..."*. Every message includes GamCare's free 24/7 number.
 - The message stays until the customer responds. They can:
 - set a deposit limit (taken straight to Responsible Play)
 - take a break
 - say they're OK
 - Their response is recorded.
2. **Marketing stops.** For 30 days after a marker, the customer receives no marketing or optional emails, unless staff review and dismiss the signal.
3. **Staff are alerted.** The Safer Gambling Lead receives an email alert linking to the signal.

4.2 Staff review

Every signal appears in the **Harm signals** queue (`/admin/harm-signals`). For each signal, staff see:

- what was observed and over what period
- the customer's deposits and stakes over the last 30 days
- the customer's other signals
- every past interaction with the customer

Staff decide what is proportionate, from light-touch to strong:

Step	When	How it's recorded
Record a note	The automated message is enough; watch for recurrence	Interaction (note)

Step	When	How it's recorded
Email or phone the customer	Medium or high severity, repeated signals, or no response to the automated message	Interaction (email / phone call), with a follow-up date
Apply a deposit limit	Spending looks unaffordable, or the customer agrees to one	Interaction (deposit limit applied). The platform only allows staff to <i>lower</i> a limit, never raise it.
Apply a cool-off	Signs of acute harm, or the customer asks	Interaction (cool-off applied)
Suspend the account	Serious concern, or no engagement after repeated interactions	Account status change with a reason (audited)
Close the account	Customer request, or strong evidence of harm	Account status change with a reason (audited)

Closing the review. Staff close the signal as **reviewed** or **dismissed**, with notes explaining what they found and decided. This is recorded in the admin audit log.

Target times:

- high-severity signals: reviewed within 24 hours
- all others: within 5 working days

Staff conduct. Staff never encourage further gambling, and never offer bonuses or incentives to a customer with an open signal. PlayStake does not currently run bonuses at all.

5. Evaluate

Automatic evaluation. Fourteen days after each interaction, the platform compares the customer's deposits and stakes in the 14 days before the interaction with the 14 days after, and records the outcome:

Outcome	Meaning
Customer took a break	A cool-off or self-exclusion was started after the interaction
Customer set a limit	A deposit limit was set or changed after the interaction
Behaviour improved	Deposits plus stakes fell to 75% or less of the previous 14 days
Behaviour unchanged	No meaningful change. Staff are alerted to consider a stronger step.

Manual outcomes. Staff can also record outcomes themselves, such as "escalated" or "no response".

6. Measuring effectiveness

The Harm signals page includes an effectiveness table. For each marker and each type of interaction, it shows how many interactions led to each outcome. Every quarter, the Safer Gambling Lead:

1. reviews the table, alongside complaint and self-exclusion trends
2. decides whether each automated message, threshold and staff response is working

3. adjusts thresholds, messages or escalation rules where it is not
4. records the conclusions and any changes in the quarterly board compliance report and in this policy's version history

7. Training

Everyone who works with customers or the admin tools is trained before starting, and every year after. The training covers:

- recognising the signs of gambling harm
- how to have a supportive conversation
- what the platform does automatically
- how to record interactions
- when to escalate

8. Records

These records are kept even if the customer's account is later deleted, for at least 5 years:

- signals
- interactions
- responses
- outcomes
- review notes

9. Review

Version	Date	Change
0.1	30 September 2026	First draft

Policy 06 — Age Verification

Operator	[COMPANY NAME], trading as PlayStake
Owner	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME], Head of Compliance
Version	0.1 — draft for licence application
Review	Annually, and when an electronic verification provider is appointed
Relates to	Licensing objective 3 (protecting children); Gambling Act 2005 ss.46–47 (inviting or permitting a child or young person to gamble); LCCP social responsibility code 3.2.11 (remote age verification: verify age before a customer can deposit, access free-to-play games, or gamble); LCCP customer identity verification requirements

Draft for review by a compliance adviser. LCCP references to be confirmed against the current version.

1. Purpose

Nobody under 18 may gamble with PlayStake. Remote operators must verify a customer's age **before** they can deposit, access free-to-play games, or gamble. This policy explains how PlayStake does that and what happens if an under-18 gets through.

2. Principles

- **Verify first.** Age is verified before any deposit, any free-to-play game, and any gambling. No product lets anyone play first and verify later.
- **Fail closed.** Anything short of full verification blocks all gambling.
- **No shortcuts.** Staff cannot mark a customer as age-verified without an approved identity document showing they are 18 or over. The platform enforces this.

3. How age is verified

3.1 At sign-up

- **Email sign-up.** Customers who sign up with email must give their date of birth and actively tick a box confirming they are 18 or over. The box also confirms that their age and identity will be checked before they can deposit or play. Anyone whose date of birth makes them under 18 is refused, and no account is created. The date of birth and the time of the confirmation are recorded.
- **Google sign-in.** Customers who sign in with Google do not give a date of birth at sign-up. They go through exactly the same identity verification (section 3.2) before they can deposit or play.
- **Marketing.** Marketing consent is a separate, unticked, optional box.

Sign-up does not verify age. It only stops an under-18 who admits their age from opening an account. Verification happens in section 3.2.

3.2 Identity and age verification (KYC)

Before any deposit, free-to-play access or gambling, the customer must complete identity verification. The steps are:

1. **Email address verified first.**
2. **Details and documents submitted.** The customer enters their legal name, date of birth and address, and uploads:
 - a passport (photo page), a driving licence (front and back) or a national ID card (front and back)
 - a selfie
3. **Automatic checks when submitted:**
 - the date of birth entered must show the customer is 18 or over
 - files must be genuine images or PDFs (checked from the file contents, not the file name) and no larger than 8 MB
 - documents are encrypted as soon as they are received (AES-256-GCM)
4. **Identity screening:**
 - the document date of birth is compared with the one given at sign-up; a mismatch opens a case and blocks approval
 - the same name and date of birth, or the same document image, on another account opens a case and blocks approval (one person, one account)
 - GAMSTOP is checked (Policy 04)
5. **Manual review by trained staff**, at `/admin/kyc`. The reviewer checks that:
 - the document is genuine and unaltered, and not expired
 - the name and date of birth on the document match what the customer entered
 - the selfie matches the document photo
 - the address is plausible and consistent
6. **Age re-checked at approval.** When the reviewer approves, the platform re-checks age from the document's date of birth. It refuses approval if the customer is under 18, and tells the reviewer to close the account as under-18 instead.
7. **Decision.** Every approval and rejection is recorded, with the reviewer and their notes, in the admin audit log. A rejection must include a reason, which the customer is told.

Outstanding (Master Manual §8 item 4). An electronic identity and age verification provider will be added to supplement manual review. It will provide document-authenticity checks, liveness detection and a credit-reference or electoral-roll age check. Until then, every submission is reviewed manually and nothing is approved automatically.

3.3 Where verification is enforced

The eligibility check (Master Manual §5.1) requires verified identity for every one of these actions:

Action	Blocked until verified?
Depositing	Yes
Entering the games (/play), including free-to-play games	Yes

Action	Blocked until verified?
Joining a lobby, sending or accepting an invite, issuing or accepting a challenge	Yes
Having a stake locked when an opponent accepts a match	Yes (the opponent is re-checked)
Withdrawing	Yes
Applying to be a referee	Verified identity is required before approval and before officiating

Explaining the block. A notice on the games page tells an unverified customer they can't play yet and links to verification.

No manual override. Staff cannot set a customer to "verified" by hand unless an approved identity document shows they are 18 or over. The attempt is refused.

4. If an under-18 is found

An under-18 may be found in several ways: at verification, through a document review, a report from a parent, or information from a payment provider. Whenever it happens, staff act at once:

1. **Close the account as under-18** from the customer's admin page, giving a reason. The platform then automatically:
 - **voids every unsettled bet** they are party to, returning both players' stakes, because an under-18 cannot lawfully win or lose a bet
 - withdraws their lobby entries, invites and challenges
 - signs them out everywhere and prevents them signing in again
 - records the action, including their balance at the time and the voided bets, in the admin audit log
2. **Return their money.** The Head of Compliance arranges for the account's deposits to be returned to their source, outside the platform. Winnings are not paid.
3. **Review settled bets.** For bets that settled before the account was closed, the Head of Compliance reviews each one:
 - stakes the customer lost are returned as part of step 2
 - opponents who lost money to the under-18 are refunded by PlayStake where appropriate
 - every decision is recorded on the customer's record
4. **Consider reporting.** Decide whether to report to the Gambling Commission (for example, as a key event if a control failed) and whether safeguarding concerns need to be raised.
5. **Learn.** Establish how the customer got through verification, and fix the cause.

An under-18 closure **cannot be reversed**. Someone who has since turned 18 must open a new account and be fully verified.

5. Marketing and product design

- PlayStake's marketing is aimed only at adults. It does not use content, games, influencers or channels with particular appeal to under-18s.

- The site footer and every email footer state "18+ only", and the Terms of Service set 18 as the minimum age. Email footers also carry GamCare's free support number.
- Streamer partners on Kick must be over 18 and verified. Their PlayStake content must not target under-18s.

6. Monitoring and testing

The Head of Compliance carries out checks every quarter:

- **Sample check.** Re-check a sample of approved identity verifications against their documents.
- **Test the controls.** Confirm that an unverified test account cannot deposit, enter the games or stake. The automated test suite also checks this on every code change.

The results are included in the quarterly board compliance report.

7. Records

- **Identity documents:** kept encrypted for the retention period in the Privacy Policy. They are only ever decrypted when a reviewer deliberately opens them.
- **Verification decisions:** kept even if the account is deleted, and recorded in the audit log.
- **Under-18 closures:** permanent on the account.

8. Review

Version	Date	Change
0.1	30 September 2026	First draft

Policy 07 — Anti-Money Laundering and Counter-Terrorist Financing: Risk Assessment and Controls

Operator	[COMPANY NAME], trading as PlayStake
Owner	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME], Money Laundering Reporting Officer (MLRO)
Version	0.1 — draft for licence application
Review	At least annually , and before launching any new product, game type, payment method or technology, or when a significant new risk or typology is identified (section 9)
Relates to	LCCP licence condition 12.1.1 (anti-money laundering: assess ML/TF risks and have appropriate policies, procedures and controls, reviewed as necessary and at least annually); Proceeds of Crime Act 2002 (POCA) Part 7; Terrorism Act 2000; sanctions regimes administered by OFSI; the Commission's guidance " <i>The prevention of money laundering and combating the financing of terrorism — guidance for remote and non-remote operators (excluding casinos)</i> "

Draft for review by a compliance adviser. **Regulatory position:** as a non-casino operator, PlayStake is expected not to be a "relevant person" under the Money Laundering, Terrorist Financing and Transfer of Funds Regulations 2017 (which apply to casino licensees). It is, however, fully subject to POCA, the Terrorism Act and the LCCP. PlayStake nevertheless applies customer due diligence, monitoring and record-keeping to a standard informed by the Regulations. *Confirm this position with legal advisers for the licence type applied for.*

All monetary thresholds below are defaults in the platform, currently in US dollars because payments are in Stripe test mode. They must be converted to pounds sterling and confirmed in this assessment before launch (Master Manual §8 items 6 and 9).

Part A — Risk assessment

A1. Method

The assessment works as follows:

1. **Identify risks.** Money laundering and terrorist financing risks are identified across six factors: customers, products and games, transactions, delivery channels, payment methods and geography.
2. **Rate inherent risk.** Each risk is rated for likelihood (Low, Medium or High) and impact (Low, Medium or High), before controls, giving an inherent risk.
3. **Rate residual risk.** Each risk is then rated again after PlayStake's controls, giving a residual risk.

Current assessment. It is based on the platform as built on 30 September 2026, before real-money launch. There is no live transaction history yet. The first review after launch must use real data (section 9).

A2. The business model and why it matters

PlayStake customers stake money against **each other** on games they play themselves. PlayStake holds both stakes in escrow and pays the winner, less a platform fee. It never takes a position.

This creates a risk that doesn't exist, or is much smaller, in house-banked betting: **value transfer between customers**. If two accounts are controlled by the same person, or by people acting together, one can deliberately lose to the other. That moves money from one account to another with a gambling transaction as cover. This is "chip dumping" (or "soft play"). The receiving account then withdraws the "winnings". It is the dominant money laundering typology for this business, and most of the controls in Part B are built around it.

A3. Risk register

#	Risk	Factor	Inherent (L × I)	Key controls (Part B)	Residual
1	Chip dumping. Colluding accounts pass value by losing on purpose.	Product / transactions	High × High = High	One-person-one-account screening (B2.3); chip-dumping detection (B3.1); head-to-head cap of 5 matches an hour (B3.2); shared-IP detection (B3.1); withdrawal holds (B4)	Medium
2	Deposit-and-withdraw without play. Criminal funds are deposited, lightly played or not played, and withdrawn as apparently legitimate funds.	Transactions	Medium × High = High	Deposit-and-withdraw-without-play detection and a real-time withdrawal hold (B3.1, B4); payouts only to a verified bank account (B4)	Low–Medium
3	Spending the proceeds of crime. A customer gambles with criminal property, a "lifestyle" risk.	Customers / transactions	Medium × High = High	Customer due diligence (CDD) before any deposit (B2); EDD and source of funds over the 30-day threshold (B2.4); affordability markers (Policy 05); per-transaction deposit cap	Medium
4	Stolen payment methods. Deposits are made with stolen or compromised cards.	Payment methods	Medium × Medium = Medium	Stripe card processing, with 3-D Secure as Stripe applies it by default; chargeback suspension and case (B3.3); <i>explicit 3-D Secure rules and Stripe Radar rules outstanding</i>	Medium (Low once Radar is live)
5	Mule and multiple accounts. Accounts are opened in other people's names, or one person runs several.	Customers	Medium × High = High	Document KYC with selfie and manual review; shared-identity and document-image matching; DOB cross-check; shared-IP detection; <i>electronic ID with liveness outstanding</i>	Medium

#	Risk	Factor	Inherent (L × I)	Key controls (Part B)	Residual
6	Result manipulation to move value. A referee or a player fixes a result.	Product	Medium × High = High	Independent referees who are verified, approved per game and never officiate their own matches; hash-chained referee audit; dispute window; overturn tracking; anomaly detection	Low–Medium
7	Sanctioned persons and PEPs.	Customers	Low × High = Medium	<i>Screening provider outstanding.</i> Interim: manual check against the OFSI consolidated list at KYC approval (B2.5).	Medium, falling to Low once automated
8	Terrorist financing. Small value transfers, including through the P2P mechanism.	Transactions	Low × High = Medium	The same controls as risks 1, 2 and 7; the MLRO reports under the Terrorism Act	Low
9	Geography. Customers or funds from high-risk or non-GB jurisdictions.	Geography	Medium × Medium = Medium	Country captured at KYC and reviewed at approval; <i>outstanding for launch: a GB-only restriction, a geolocation check, and automatic refusal of FATF high-risk jurisdictions</i>	Low–Medium
10	Insider facilitation. Staff approve identities improperly, lift restrictions or ignore alerts.	Delivery	Low × High = Medium	Staff 2FA; append-only admin audit log; platform-enforced limits on staff actions; quarterly independent review of cases	Low
11	Streamer and audience channel. Viewers on Kick challenge streamers; a streamer's audience could be used to channel funds.	Delivery channel	Medium × Medium = Medium	All the same controls apply to streamer challenges (it is the same lobby and escrow); referee oversight; head-to-head cap; chip-dumping detection	Low–Medium

Overall residual risk: Medium. This is driven by risks 1, 3 and 5. It is expected to fall once the outstanding provider-based controls (electronic ID, sanctions/PEP screening, Stripe Radar) are live, and after the first review based on live data.

Part B — Policies, procedures and controls

B1. Roles

- **The MLRO**, [COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME]:
 - owns this assessment
 - decides AML cases

- makes Suspicious Activity Reports (SARs) and Defence Against Money Laundering (DAML) requests to the NCA
- trains staff
- reports to the board every quarter
- **All staff** must report any knowledge or suspicion of money laundering to the MLRO promptly. They can do this by adding a note to a case in the AML queue, or by telling the MLRO directly. Failing to report is an offence under POCA s.330.

B2. Customer due diligence

B2.1 Before any deposit

Identity is verified before any deposit, any play and any withdrawal (Policy 06):

- legal name, date of birth and address
- a photo identity document and a selfie
- manual review by trained staff

B2.2 Ongoing monitoring

- The monitoring in B3 runs on every account.
- Customers' circumstances are reviewed whenever a case is raised.

B2.3 One person, one account

At KYC, the new submission is matched against every other account:

- **Same legal name and date of birth, or the same document image** → a `SHARED_IDENTITY` case, and approval is blocked.
- **Document date of birth differs from the one given at sign-up** → a `DOB_MISMATCH` case, and approval is blocked.

B2.4 Enhanced due diligence (EDD) and source of funds

- **Trigger:** completed deposits over any 30 days at or above **5,000.00** (setting `AML_EDD_THRESHOLD_CENTS`). This opens a `HIGH_DEPOSIT_VOLUME` case.
- **What the MLRO obtains:** evidence of source of funds, such as payslips, bank statements or other documents appropriate to the amount, and, where needed, source of wealth.
- **What happens meanwhile:**
 - while the case is open, withdrawals are held (B4)
 - the MLRO may suspend the account if evidence is not provided within [14] days
- **Other EDD triggers:** EDD also applies when a customer:
 - is a PEP or connected to one (once screening is live)
 - is linked to a high-risk jurisdiction
 - is the subject of any high-severity case

B2.5 Sanctions and PEPs

Outstanding. A screening provider is to be appointed.

Interim control. Until then, at KYC approval the reviewer checks the customer's name and date of birth against the OFSI consolidated list, and notes the check in the review notes.

If a customer is a sanctions match:

1. do not approve the account
2. freeze their funds
3. report to OFSI
4. inform the MLRO

B3. Transaction monitoring

A scan runs **every 15 minutes**. Its results are cases in the **AML queue** (/admin/aml), and each new case alerts the MLRO by email.

B3.1 Automated detectors

Detector	Case type	Triggered when	Severity
Chip dumping	CHIP_DUMPING (receiver, with the sender linked)	The same two players played 5 or more times in 7 days, one side won 80% or more of decided games, and received at least 100.00 net (AML_CHIP_DUMP_VALUE_CENTS)	Medium; high at 10+ games or 5× the value
Shared IP, played each other	SHARED_IP (both linked)	Two accounts used the same IP address in the last 30 days and wagered against each other	High
Many accounts on one IP	SHARED_IP	Four or more accounts on one IP address in 30 days	Low (for review; households and public networks are common)
Deposit and withdraw without play	DEPOSIT_WITHDRAW_NO_PLAY	Deposits of at least 50.00 in 7 days (AML_NO_PLAY_MIN_DEPOSIT_CENTS), at least half withdrawn within 24 hours, and less than a quarter of the deposits staked	Medium
Deposits over the EDD threshold	HIGH_DEPOSIT_VOLUME	See B2.4	Medium; high at 2×
Identity	SHARED_IDENTITY , DOB_MISMATCH	See B2.3	High / Medium
Chargeback	CHARGEBACK	A card issuer dispute on a deposit	High

Signal frequency. Only one open case exists per customer, type and counterparty, so a continuing pattern doesn't flood the queue.

B3.2 Preventive controls

- **Head-to-head cap.** The same two customers can play each other at most **5 times in any hour**. Further matches are refused.
- **No self-play.** The database refuses a bet between an account and itself.
- **Deposit caps.** Each deposit must be between 5.00 and 1,000.00.

B3.3 Chargebacks

A card dispute on a deposit has two immediate effects:

- the account is **suspended**, so no stakes or withdrawals can be made
- a high-severity case is opened for the MLRO

B4. Withdrawal controls

Withdrawals are where laundered funds leave. A withdrawal request is **held for review**, and not paid, when any of these apply:

Condition	What happens
The account is suspended or closed	The withdrawal is refused
A medium- or high-severity AML case is open on the account	The withdrawal is held. Low-severity cases, such as a shared household IP, do not hold money.
The amount is at or above 2,000.00 (<code>AML_WITHDRAWAL_REVIEW_THRESHOLD_CENTS</code>)	A review case is opened and the withdrawal is held
The withdrawal follows deposits with little play (the B3.1 rule, counting the requested amount)	A <code>DEPOSIT_WITHDRAW_NO_PLAY</code> case is opened and the withdrawal is held

Customer message. The customer is told only that the withdrawal "needs a quick review" and that their balance is safe. They are never told about a suspicion.

Clearing a hold. When the MLRO closes the case with **no suspicion**, withdrawals of the same kind go through for the following 7 days.

Where payouts go. Payouts go only to the customer's own bank account, verified through the payment provider (Stripe Connect), after identity and email verification. *Outstanding: automatically matching the payout account holder's name to the verified legal name. Until then, the MLRO checks this manually for any held withdrawal.*

Exclusion never traps funds. Self-exclusion and GAMSTOP registration never block a withdrawal (Policies 03 and 04). Only AML and fraud controls do.

B5. Case handling and suspicious activity reporting

Every AML case is worked in the AML queue:

1. **Assign.** The investigator or MLRO takes the case.
2. **Investigate.** Review the customer's identity, transactions, betting pattern, counterparties and linked cases. Record notes on the case.
3. **Decide.** The MLRO records the reasoning for every decision on the case. The platform requires it. The decision is one of:
 - **close, no suspicion:** releases held withdrawals of that kind for 7 days
 - **close, action taken:** for example, the account was suspended or closed, or winnings were withheld under the Terms
 - **escalate to the MLRO:** where an investigator has worked the case
 - **SAR submitted:** the MLRO records the NCA reference on the case
4. **Report.** Where the MLRO knows or suspects money laundering or terrorist financing, or has reasonable grounds to, they make a SAR to the NCA through the SAR Online portal as soon as practicable. Where PlayStake would otherwise pay out or process funds it suspects are criminal property, the MLRO requests a **DAML** first, and the funds stay held (the withdrawal hold) until consent is given or the statutory period ends. Every SAR decision is recorded, including decisions *not* to report and why.
5. **Don't tip off.** Nobody may tell the customer, or anyone else, that a SAR has been considered or made, or that an investigation is under way (POCA s.333A). The customer-facing messages are written with this in mind. The AML case page reminds staff.
6. **Notify the Commission** where the LCCP requires it. SARs themselves are not shared with the Commission except as the law allows.

Every action on a case is recorded in the append-only admin audit log.

B6. Record keeping

The following are kept for **at least 5 years** after the business relationship ends, or after the transaction for occasional transactions:

- CDD records and documents
- transaction and ledger records (the double-entry ledger is immutable by design)
- AML cases and their notes and decisions
- SAR decisions and references

These records are protected from deletion with the customer's account. SAR-related records are held so that they can be produced to the NCA or the courts when required.

B7. Training

All staff receive AML training before starting and every year after. It covers:

- the offences (POCA ss.327–330 and s.333A; the Terrorism Act)
- PlayStake's typologies, especially chip dumping
- red flags
- how to report to the MLRO
- tipping off

The MLRO keeps training records and tests understanding.

B8. Governance

The MLRO reports every quarter to the board on:

- case volumes by type
- time to decision
- SARs and DAMLs (numbers only)
- withdrawal holds
- any control weaknesses

The quarterly independent review (Master Manual §3) samples closed cases.

Part C — Review triggers

This assessment is reviewed **at least annually**, and before or immediately after any of these:

- a new product, game type or match type (for example, a new third-party game category)
- a new payment method, currency or payout route, including the move from test mode to live payments in GBP
- new technology, such as a new identity or verification provider, or a change to how results are determined
- entering a new market or jurisdiction
- a significant change in volumes or customer behaviour, or a new typology seen in cases or in Commission or NCA publications
- a material control failure, or findings from the independent review

The first live-data review must be carried out **3 months after real-money launch**. It will re-rate each risk using real transaction data and recalibrate the thresholds in B2.4, B3.1 and B4.

Version history

Version	Date	Change
0.1	30 September 2026	First draft, pre-launch assessment